McNamara got it right: the *Gagarin* was indeed carrying missiles. The ship left Mykolaiv late in the evening of October 10 with equipment for the two detachments of the R-14 missile regiment stationed in the Ukrainian city of Okhtyrka. When crossing the Bosporus, the ship had given its destination as Conakry, but a Turkish navigator at the straits had suggested that in fact it was headed for Cuba, so the true destination seemed to be an open secret. Early in the morning of October 22, the day Kennedy gave his television address, the *Gagarin* was approaching the Bahamas, where it encountered a US Navy ship that ordered it to stop. The captain ignored the order. After numerous further attempts to signal the *Gagarin*, the American vessel left: the whole episode had lasted less than fifty minutes.[15]

The *Kimovsk* was also guilty as charged. In August that Finnish-built cargo ship, whose home port was Leningrad, delivered to Cuba thirty-one Soviet tanks and 150 officers and soldiers from the 6th Tank Army of the Kyiv military district. On September 22 it returned to Cuba, delivering a 2,200-ton load, including eight medium-range R-12 missiles and officers and soldiers of the 79th Missile Regiment of Colonel Ivan Sidorov. His missiles would be combat-ready on October 10. Now the *Kimovsk* was back, carrying intermediate R-14 or SS-5 Skean missiles and the units that serviced and operated them.[16]

“Both of these ships,” McNamara told the ExCom, “are good targets for our first intercept.” He then added: “Admiral Anderson’s plan is to try to intercept one or both of them today.” The reference was to the chief of naval operations, Admiral George Whelan Anderson Jr. John Kennedy was concerned about the details of the operation. “Which one are they going to try to get?” the president asked his secretary of defense. “Both of them?” McNamara’s response was in the affirmative, although he considered the *Kimovsk* the primary target. “What kind of ship is going to try to intercept?” continued Kennedy. “A destroyer?” He was informed that the aircraft carrier *Essex*, with antisubmarine helicopters on board, was getting ready to help intercept the Soviet ships by diverting the Soviet submarines that were presumably escorting them from the point of interception.

Suddenly, McCone interrupted what seemed to be a Kennedy-McNamara discussion: “Mr. President, I have a note just handed to me.… All six Soviet ships currently identified in Cuban waters—and I don’t know